Income Support Is Not a Guaranteed Cognitive Intervention

Poverty is associated with developmental disadvantage through multiple pathways; Baby's First Years shows a defined monthly cash transfer can change infant brain activity without producing preregistered age-four cognitive gains.

: MODERATE-GRADIENT; LOW-TO-MODERATE-CASH-COGNITION | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: ECOLOGY, POLICY | REPLICATION: VE

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Low income is consistently associated with developmental and health disadvantage. That association mixes material deprivation, stress, housing, nutrition, service access, and selection. Baby's First Years randomized mothers to a larger versus smaller monthly cash transfer. Troller-Renfree et al. (2022) reported greater mid-to-high-frequency infant EEG power in the high-cash group (standardized effects about 0.17–0.26). Noble et al. (2025) reported no statistically significant differences on preregistered language, executive-function, social-emotional, and related developmental outcomes at age four.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

BFY is an RCT of a defined transfer, not an estimate of eliminating poverty. Observational gradients are not this card's causal claim. Adjacent GI-attenuated cards (prenatal stress; breastfeeding IQ) already warn against treating family-level associations as parenting effects. Childcare quality remains a different exposure.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Report the infant EEG effect separately from the age-four nulls. Do not infer that a small early neural difference is a durable developmental benefit, or that a null result means poverty is harmless.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (randomized controlled cash transfer trial, not an observational parenting phenotype).

Effects may depend on transfer size, duration, baseline deprivation, local prices, and other services. The trial does not estimate broader anti-poverty packages.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Poverty is not evidence of low parental commitment. The BFY null does not show that material conditions have no causal effects. Cash is not a substitute for housing, health care, or childcare quality.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Treat income support as a material-security and anti-poverty policy first. Evaluate developmental outcomes directly rather than promising universal cognitive gains.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Troller-Renfree et al. (2022), PNAS
- Noble et al. (2025), NBER working paper w33844